his backing. The Bihar CM has been the fulcrum of Bihar politics since 2005 when his party decisively won that year's second assembly polls. Barring the 2014 Lok Sabha election—when Bihar, like the entire country, was swept by the Narendra Modi wave—the winner in every assembly (2010, 2015 and 2020) and general election (2009, 2019) was led by the alliance led by Nitish. "You may call him out over the alliance-hopping, but is it not a fact that both the RJD and BJP have accepted and formed alliances with him again and again?" asks a senior JD(U) leader.

NITISH FELT A DEAL WITH THE BJP WOULD HELP HIM CONSOLIDATE SUPPORT AMONG THE 26 PER CENT HINDU EBCs

NO CONFIDENCE IN I.N.D.I.A.

So why did Nitish turn his back on an Opposition alliance he had worked so hard to put together? Talk of a national Opposition alliance for 2024 with various leaders had started in September 2022, a month after he formed a new government with the RJD and Congress. The Bihar chief minister held the first meeting of a possible Opposition alliance at his Patna residence in June 2023. But as months went by, things did not pan out as he wanted, with alliance members indifferent to his national ambitions and his idea on an all-party campaign for a national caste census. Indeed, he was not even offered the convenor position for I.N.D.I.A.

When the results of the assembly polls in the three Hindi heartland states came out on December 3—confirming the BJP's sweep—the JD(U) chief may have realised he was betting on a dead horse. By this time, the saffron party had also begun sending feelers. Trusted aide and JD(U) national general secretary Sanjay Jha was apparently given the go-ahead to initiate a dialogue with his contacts in the BJP. A former close associate of the late Arun Jaitley, Jha had left the saffron party for the JD(U) in 2012.

JD(U) sources say that by the time I.N.D.I.A. held its fourth meeting in Delhi on December 19, Nitish had already made up his mind. This was the meeting where Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge was proposed as the prime ministerial candidate by alliance members Trinamool Congress (TMC) and the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP). The JD(U) chief was not impressed. "The reasons are simple. Nitish had even publicly promised to hand over Bihar's reins to Tejashwi...but a feeling of betrayal was evident at the alliance not even considering him for a national role," says a JD(U) leader.

An aggrieved Nitish soon moved into mission mode, first by taking over as the JD(U) president on December 29, a position that put him in command of the party organisation as well. By then, backchannel talks had already come some way, with Nitish believed to have spoken to top BJP leaders. By January 13, when I.N.D.I.A. had a virtual meeting to review the seat-sharing agenda and Kharge asked Nitish to take over as convenor, the Bihar CM was in the last stages of finalising the *gharwapsi* deal with the BJP. For the record, he declined Kharge's offer.

Things moved quickly after that Makar Sankranti feast on January 15. On the 23rd, Nitish held a meeting with governor Rajendra Arlekar amidst the buzz of a rift between the alliance partners. He is also believed to have spoken on the phone to a top BJP leader who promised support to form an alternative government. The same evening, Prime Minister Narendra Modi tweeted to share his delight about former Bihar chief minister and socialist icon Karpoori Thakur being posthumously awarded the Bharat Ratna. Nitish likes to project himself as an ardent follower of Thakur.

The very next day, Nitish attacked "dynastic rule" in parties while paying homage to Thakur on his birth centenary. This clearly escalated tensions within the *mahagathbandhan*, as 'dynastic politics' has long been a BJP refrain against Tejashwi and the Congress's Rahul Gandhi. The response from the Lalu camp was swift, with Tejashwi's Singapore-based sister Rohini Acharya posting scathing remarks on social media platform X without naming Nitish. Though she eventually deleted her post, the JD(U) had taken note of it.

The chasm between the two parties came to the fore at the Republic Day function in Patna's Gandhi Maidan where governor Arlekar unfurled the national flag. Though Nitish and Tejashwi shared the stage—their chairs separated by a few feet—the silence between them indicated that the 17-month-old alliance was teetering on the brink.

TEJASHWI'S CHALLENGE

The 34-year-old former deputy CM has actually emerged from this whole unsavoury episode as a mature leader, with measured criticism of Nitish even after he walked out of the Opposition alliance. His "*Khel abhi baaki hai* (The